

UNCLASSIFIED · OPEN-SOURCE INTELLIGENCE · AS OF 17 JULY 2026 (UPDATED; ORIGINALLY 2 JULY 2026) · TOPIC:
DISINFORMATION & INFLUENCE OPERATIONS

Pro-AI Influence Operations and the "Foreign Influence" Counter-Narrative Against Data-Center Opposition

Prepared from Aunoo news-intelligence and named primary reporting

BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT

Two separate campaigns are working to shape public opinion in the fight over AI data centers in the United States. WIRED reported on 1 May 2026 that Build American AI, a dark-money group tied to the pro-AI super PAC Leading the Future, paid social-media influencers to promote American AI and frame China as the threat, with related reporting alleging an automated pseudo-news site and bot-like amplification around the same network. A second campaign, built on reports from the Bitcoin Policy Institute (BPI) and the group Power the Future, argues that opposition to AI data centers is itself a China-linked foreign influence operation.

The evidence is asymmetric. The pro-AI influencer campaign is well documented, with named actors and campaign materials. The claim that anti-data-center opposition is foreign-driven is **not supported by the available evidence**: OpenAI found no meaningful breakout for the China-origin activity it flagged, WIRED reported that Graphika saw no scaled foreign operation, and one analysis found a majority of opposition is Republican-led. The BPI material is best interpreted as the policy-paper layer of a pro-AI counter-campaign, supplying an evidentiary-looking frame that lawmakers and investors already cite, though no public evidence shows it is directly coordinated with the pro-AI network.

What happened

WIRED documented a coordinated campaign in which Build American AI, tied to Leading the Future, paid lifestyle and political influencers, reportedly around \$5,000 per TikTok video, to promote American AI and present China as the threat. The campaign sits in a large political-finance network. Axios reported that Leading the Future raised more than \$125 million, with contributors including OpenAI cofounder Greg Brockman, Andreessen Horowitz, and Perplexity, and the Financial Times sized the wider AI and crypto PAC environment at roughly \$250 million to \$300 million ahead of the midterms. OpenAI and Palantir deny corporate involvement, and OpenAI says it does not direct or fund Leading the Future and opposes astroturfing. Model Republic, corroborated in part by Tom's Hardware and The Verge, alleged an automated pseudo-news site staffed by AI "reporters" and bot-like amplification on X; those claims are treated here as credible leads rather than settled fact.

Beginning in mid-May, BPI published "Foreign Influence in the Campaign against American AI," followed by "The Singham Ground Game" on 29 June, arguing that opposition to data centers runs parallel to a China-linked campaign centered on Neville Roy Singham and the Party for Socialism and Liberation, and claiming roughly \$23.6 billion in blocked investment. The framing moved quickly into official channels. House Energy and Commerce members, Senator Tom Cotton, and Representative John Moolenaar cited the reports to seek FBI and DOJ investigations, and investor Kevin O'Leary used a BPI graphic to allege foreign influence behind opposition to his own data-center project.

Key facts at a glance

PRO-AI CAMPAIGN Build American AI paid influencers (WIRED, 1 May 2026)	FUNDING NETWORK Leading the Future \$125m+; AI lobby valued ~\$250–300m
CORPORATE DISTANCING OpenAI, Palantir deny involvement; OpenAI opposes astroturfing	COUNTER-NARRATIVE BPI & Power the Future "foreign influence" reports
OFFICIAL UPTAKE GOP lawmakers seek FBI/DOJ probes citing the reports	STRONGEST COUNTER-EVIDENCE No breakout (OpenAI); no scaled op (Graphika); ~55% opposition GOP-led

Indicative timeline

Jan–Apr 26	Leading the Future raises \$125m+; FT sizes AI/crypto PAC funding at ~\$250–300m ahead of the midterms
Apr 26	Model Republic publishes the Acutus pseudo-news investigation; The Verge and Tom's Hardware pick it up
1 May 26	WIRED reports Build American AI paying influencers to spread pro-AI and China-threat messaging
18 May 26	BPI publishes Part I of the "Foreign Influence" report
4 Jun 26	Three GOP House members request FBI briefings, citing BPI and Power the Future
10 Jun 26	OpenAI's "Data Center Bandwagon" report: likely China-linked accounts, no meaningful breakout
10–11 Jun 26	Sen. Cotton and Rep. Moolenaar seek DOJ investigation, citing Singham and BPI
12 Jun 26	WIRED, "China Didn't Make Americans Hate Data Centers," reports expert skepticism
11 May–3 Jun 26	Kevin O'Leary alleges across at least ten media appearances that two named Utah groups are CCP "cells" behind opposition to his data center
25 Jun 26	O'Leary states on Instagram that he has "no evidence" the named groups or individuals are funded by China or the CCP
29–30 Jun 26	BPI publishes Part II and a press release amplifying the \$23.6bn claim
15 Jul 26	Alliance for a Better Utah and Elevate Strategies sue O'Leary and Fox News for defamation in Utah Federal District Court

Why this matters

Venue shift. The counter-narrative recasts a local dispute about energy, water, land, and electricity prices as a national-security and counterintelligence matter, moving it toward the FBI, DOJ, and congressional oversight and raising the cost of ordinary civic opposition.

Relocated accusation. After the pro-AI campaign was exposed, the counter-narrative moves the charge of manufactured activity onto opponents. That is the practical function the BPI material performs, whether or not it is coordinated.

Weaponized concern. Foreign actors do test domestic grievances, and OpenAI found a real if minor attempt. The risk is stretching a legitimate monitoring concern into blanket suspicion of a broad domestic movement, which degrades foreign-influence analysis when it is most needed.

Update, 17 July 2026: the frame meets a legal test. Kevin O'Leary attributed opposition to his Utah data-center project to CCP-linked activity across at least ten media appearances. On 25 June he stated on Instagram that he had "no evidence" the named Utah groups or individuals are funded by China or the CCP, which the plaintiffs' firm says followed a legal demand. On 15 July, Alliance for a Better Utah and Elevate Strategies sued O'Leary and Fox News for defamation. Both defendants contest the suit; O'Leary's counsel calls it a "cash grab" and says he welcomes discovery. Nothing is adjudicated and a complaint is an allegation, but the most prominent individual applying this frame to a specific project stated in writing that he could not support it.

ASSESSMENT

BPI's material is **very likely a functional component of a pro-AI counter-campaign** rather than an independent finding, on the basis of narrative fit, timing, and downstream political use. It is **not established as directly coordinated with or funded by** the Build American AI or Leading the Future network. Confidence: moderate to high on the functional interpretation; low on any claim of direct coordination.

Consensus and forecast outlook (Aunoo cross-source analysis)

On Aunoo's tracking of the reporting, news coverage of AI-related influence operations peaked around 8 June 2026 and has since declined, so attention to this specific dispute is past its peak while the underlying data-center fight continues. The tone of that coverage is strongly negative and growing more so, with the sharpest downward shift on 23 June and no reversal yet in sight. Across reporting on influence operations more broadly, coverage converges on one mechanism in particular: influence conducted through legitimate-looking intermediaries rather than crude propaganda, which is what is visible on both sides of this dispute. Coverage of the China-influence claim splits along partisan lines, with right-leaning outlets amplifying the foreign-influence framing and center and left-leaning and specialist technology outlets foregrounding the weakness of the evidence.

Outlook and indicators to watch

- **Federal action.** Whether any agency opens an inquiry; even a preliminary one would strengthen the counter-narrative regardless of its findings.
- **Attributable evidence.** Any documentation tying named US campaigns to foreign funding, none of which exists in the public record so far.
- **Stack linkage.** Reporting connecting the influencer, pseudo-news, and policy-paper layers through shared money or contractors.
- **Utah discovery.** The defamation case is the first mechanism that could compel evidence about both the accusation and the plaintiffs' funding and coordination. Whether it survives early motions signals the legal risk of naming domestic opponents as foreign agents.
- **Midterm intensification.** The AI PAC money is aimed at the 2026 elections and federal AI regulation, so both narratives are likely to sharpen.

Source assessment and confidence

The pro-AI influencer campaign rests on high-credibility direct reporting by WIRED and is treated as well established; the funding context is corroborated by Axios and the Financial Times. OpenAI's distancing statement, via Business Insider, limits corporate attribution. The pseudo-news and bot-amplification claims originate with the advocacy-adjacent outlet Model Republic and are corroborated in part by Tom's Hardware and The Verge for the Acutus investigation; they are

credible leads rather than settled fact. The existence and political uptake of the BPI and Power the Future reports are well documented across the Washington Times, Fox News, Newsmax, PCMag, Gizmodo, TechRadar, Axios, and Politico and NPR syndication. The underlying causal claim of foreign-driven opposition is not corroborated, with the strongest contrary evidence from OpenAI's own report, WIRED's account of Graphika's assessment, and coverage of the largely Republican opposition. **Confidence:** high on the pro-AI campaign and the counter-narrative's existence and uptake; moderate to high on the functional interpretation of BPI; low on direct coordination and on the foreign-driven-opposition claim.

Sources

- WIRED — A Dark-Money Campaign Is Paying Influencers to Frame Chinese AI as a Threat (1 May 2026)
- WIRED — China Didn't Make Americans Hate Data Centers (12 Jun 2026)
- Axios — OpenAI's Brockman and a16z funnel cash to pro-AI super PAC (30 Jan 2026)
- Financial Times — Crypto and AI PACs raise \$250mn ahead of US midterm elections; Democrats cautioned against angering \$300mn AI lobby
- Business Insider — OpenAI draws a line between the company and a cofounder's political donations (2 Jun 2026)
- OpenAI — PRC-linked influence operations are targeting AI debates in the US (10 Jun 2026)
- Bitcoin Policy Institute — Foreign Influence in the Campaign against American AI, Parts I and II
- Washington Times — Three GOP congressmen probe foreign efforts to block U.S. data center build-out (4 Jun 2026)
- Fox News — Sen. Tom Cotton urges DOJ to probe Chinese bid to "kneecap" American AI (10 Jun 2026)
- Gizmodo — Republicans Claim Anti-Data Center Movement Is a Chinese Psy-Op (5 Jun 2026)
- TechRadar — Republicans call on FBI to investigate anti-data-center sentiment, despite 55% of opposition being Republican-led (9 Jun 2026)
- Model Republic; Tom's Hardware; The Verge — the Acutus AI-"reporter" pseudo-news investigation and pickup
- Fortune — Kevin O'Leary claimed opposition to his Utah data center was fueled by Chinese money. Now he and Fox News are being sued for defamation (17 Jul 2026)
- The Hill; CBC News; KSL; Daily Caller — corroborating coverage of the Utah defamation suit (16–17 Jul 2026)
- Gallup — Seven in ten Americans oppose an AI data center being built in their area (May 2026)

Compiled via Aunoo news-intelligence. Volume, sentiment, and consensus signals are derived from Aunoo's tracking of AI and disinformation news coverage. This situation report synthesizes open-source reporting and should be verified against primary statements before use in decision-making. Attribution in influence operations is probabilistic; confidence levels are stated throughout. © Aunoo.